What is Democracy? Why Democracy?

The big idea

Democracy is the most common form of government today, but not every country that calls itself a democracy really is one. This chapter builds a clear **definition of democracy** step by step, using real examples, and then weighs the **arguments for and against** it.

SIMPLE DEFINITION

Democracy is a form of government in which the rulers are elected by the people. The word comes from the Greek *demokratia*: *demos* (people) and *kratia* (rule). Abraham Lincoln described it as government "of the people, by the people, for the people".

Features of democracy

The simple definition is not enough: we must separate democracies from non-democracies that hold sham elections. Four features complete the definition.

1. Major decisions by elected leaders

In **Pakistan**, General **Pervez Musharraf** led a military coup in **October 1999**, declared himself "Chief Executive" and later President by a **referendum** (2002). He changed the constitution through a "Legal Framework Order"; elected representatives had some powers but the final power rested with military officers and Musharraf.

Lesson: in a democracy, the final decision-making power must rest with those **elected by the people**.

2. Free and fair electoral competition

In **China**, elections are held regularly for the National People's Congress, but candidates need the approval of the **Chinese Communist Party**; the government is always formed by the Communist Party. In **Mexico**, elections for President have been held every six years since **1930** and the country was never under military rule, yet until **2000** every election was won by the **PRI (Institutional Revolutionary Party)**, using many dirty tricks.

Lesson: elections must offer a **real choice** between political alternatives, and those in power should be able to lose.

3. One person, one vote, one value

Democracy is based on **political equality**. Yet in **Saudi Arabia women did not have the right to vote until 2015**; in **Estonia**, citizenship rules made it difficult for people of the Russian minority to vote; in **Fiji** the electoral system gave more value to the vote of an indigenous Fijian than to an Indian-Fijian.

Lesson: each adult citizen must have **one vote** and each vote must have **equal value**.

4. Rule of law and respect for rights

Zimbabwe became independent in **1980** (from white minority rule). Since then it was ruled by **ZANU-PF**, led by **Robert Mugabe**. Elections were held but Mugabe used unfair practices; opposition workers were harassed, public protests declared illegal, critics punished, the constitution amended to increase the President's powers, and court judgments ignored. He was removed in 2017.

Lesson: a democratic government rules **within limits set by constitutional law and citizens' rights**. Popular approval alone does not make a government democratic.

THE FULL DEFINITION

Democracy is a form of government in which: (a) rulers elected by the people take all major decisions; (b) elections offer a free and fair choice and opportunity to change rulers; (c) this choice and opportunity is available to

all the people on an equal basis; and (d) the exercise of this choice leads to a government limited by basic rules of the constitution and citizens' rights.

Arguments against democracy

- Leaders keep changing, which leads to **instability**.
- Democracy is all about political **competition and power play**; there is no scope for morality.
- So many people have to be consulted that it leads to **delays**.
- Elected leaders do not know the best interest of the people, leading to **bad decisions**.
- It leads to **corruption** because it is based on electoral competition.
- Ordinary people don't know what is good for them; they should not decide anything.

Arguments for democracy

Take the example of the **famine in China (1958–1961)**: about **three crore** people died, the worst famine in world history. India's economic condition then was not much better, but India did not have such a famine, because a democratic government responds to people's needs, and a free press and opposition would have raised the alarm.

1. A democratic government is a **better government** because it is more **accountable** and responsive to the needs of the people.
2. Democracy **improves the quality of decision-making**: it is based on consultation and discussion; many people put their minds together.
3. Democracy provides a method to **deal with differences and conflicts** peacefully, important in a diverse country like India.
4. Democracy **enhances the dignity of citizens**: it is based on political equality; the poorest and the richest have the same status.

5. Democracy **allows us to correct our own mistakes**: there is space for public discussion, and the rulers can be changed.

BROADER MEANINGS OF DEMOCRACY

Most common form is **representative democracy**: the majority rule through their elected representatives, because modern democracies have too many people to sit together and decide, and citizens lack time and knowledge to decide everything. Democracy can also mean democratic values in families, schools and organisations. **No country is a perfect democracy**; it is an ideal we keep working towards.

ELECTIONS ALONE DO NOT MAKE A DEMOCRACY

China, Pakistan under Musharraf and Zimbabwe all held elections. Elections must be free, fair, give equal votes and lead to a government that respects the rule of law and rights.

Quick recap

- Democracy: rulers elected by the people, plus four conditions.
- Examples: Pakistan (elected leaders), China and Mexico (free and fair competition), Saudi Arabia, Estonia, Fiji (one person one vote), Zimbabwe (rule of law).
- Arguments for: accountability, better decisions, handling conflict, dignity, correcting mistakes.
- Arguments against: instability, delays, corruption, bad decisions.
- Chinese famine (1958–61) shows why accountable government matters.

Practice questions

1. Which country was ruled by General Pervez Musharraf after a military coup in 1999?
   (a) Bangladesh (b) Zimbabwe (c) Pakistan (d) Mexico
2. In Mexico, the PRI won every election from 1930 until
   (a) 1980 (b) 1990 (c) 2015 (d) 2000
3. Which of these is an example of the lack of "one person, one vote, one value"?
   (a) In Fiji, an indigenous Fijian's vote had more value than an Indian-Fijian's (b) In China, the Communist Party forms every government (c) In Zimbabwe, court judgments were ignored (d) In Pakistan, the army held final power
4. Robert Mugabe ruled which country?
   (a) Kenya (b) South Africa (c) Fiji (d) Zimbabwe
5. The famine in China between 1958 and 1961 is used to argue that democracy
   (a) leads to delays in decisions (b) is more accountable and responsive to people's needs (c) leads to political instability (d) cannot handle conflicts
6. Which is NOT an argument for democracy?
   (a) It enhances the dignity of citizens (b) It allows us to correct our own mistakes (c) It improves the quality of decision-making (d) It leads to quick decisions without consultation
7. "Popular governments can be undemocratic." Explain with an example.
8. Give any five arguments in favour of democracy.

Answers: 1. c 2. d 3. a 4. d 5. b 6. d 7. see notes 8. see notes